

|By Ambreesh Mishra|

Deep in the heart of craggy Bundelkhand, the exploration team of Rio Tinto Diamonds used to zealously guard its promising finds in Chhatarpur district's Buxwaha tehsil that would lead to the discovery of the only diamond resource in the country in the last 50 years. The project was called 'Bunder' (monkey) after the thousands of monkeys in the area.

Since prospecting under license began in 2006, the area has turned out to be seven times richer than the lone functional diamond mine in neighbouring Panna. Bunder's production is likely to be 20 times more than that of Panna. It comprises a cluster of eight lamproite rock formations where the project's order of magnitude study has identified an inferred resource of 37 million tonnes at a grade of 0.7 carat per tonne. Says Rio Tinto's Project Director Stefanie Loader, "Madhya Pradesh would rank among the top ten diamond producing regions in the world when mining at the project goes ahead full steam."

What began as exploration in 2003 under reconnaissance permits resulted in a Rs 33-crore state-of-the-

DIAMOND MINERS AT THE BUNDER PROJECT SITE: A MINER LOOKS FOR A ROUGH DIAMOND (RIGHT)



Bringing on THE SHINE

The Bunder Project is set to turn this backward area into one of the top ten diamond mining regions in the world



art sample processing plant with the capacity to process 10 tonnes of rock and soil per hour. The project has received Stage-1 forest clearance and clearance for Stage-2 is expected. "The state Government is eager that mining begins at the site," says Madhya Pradesh Mining Secretary

S.K. Mishra. The state Government will get an ad valorem mining royalty of 10 per cent on the sale of diamonds.

The National Mineral Development Corporation's (NMDC) diamond mine in Panna is also up and running after a long hiatus. Since Andhra Pradesh's Golconda mines that pro-

duced famous diamonds like the Koh-i-Noor, Panna has been the country's lone deposit of the sparkling rocks.

However, the Panna mine that produces .50 to .70 carat diamonds from every tonne of scoop deep from the bowels of the kimberlite pipe had hit a snafu in 2003 when it applied for